

**Unit 1, Option D,
Topic D3: Russia
in Revolution,
1881-1924: From
Autocracy to
Dictatorship**

The focus of this topic is on the breakdown of the Tsarist autocracy under the impact of social and economic change and the shock of war, and the emergence of a new form of autocracy. Since the focus of Unit 1 is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the content bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the content bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

Collectively, the four bullet points of the specification offer a framework for understanding the themes of the exercise of power and the influence of ideology. Bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example the importance of war in weakening and even destroying regimes is covered in bullet points 1, 2 and 3.

The first bullet point relates to the reign of Alexander III and the first half of the reign of his son. Students should understand the nature of the autocracy, the use of repression and the anti-reformist stance in the wake of the assassination of Alexander II. They should be aware of urbanisation and industrialisation transforming the Russian Empire and the growth of reformist/revolutionary groups such as the Kadets, the Social Revolutionaries and the Social Democrats. They should understand the causes of the 1905 revolution, including the impact of the Russo-Japanese War, and the nature, extent and significance of that revolution.

The second bullet point relates to the last 11 years of the Romanovs. Students should understand the constitutional developments of these years in order to assess how far the autocracy was modified. They should also be able to explore how far Stolypin transformed rural Russia in the years before his assassination in 1911. They should understand the importance of the First World War in undermining Tsarism and what precipitated the February Revolution.